

Motion passed to request paused implementation of ADAP program

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Herald photo by ALEXANDRA NOAD Community members fill up council chambers to show their support for the motion brought to council by Councillor Belinda Crowson.

By Alexandra Noad

Local Journalism Initiative Reporter- Lethbridge Herald

It was standing room only in the City of Lethbridge council chambers yesterday afternoon as a motion was passed unanimously to send a letter to the Alberta government requesting them to pause implementing the Alberta Disability Assistance Program (ADAP) until proper consultation with people with disabilities is made.

The motion was brought forward by Councillor Belinda Crowson who said as a member of council she is used to hearing people's anger on issues, but on this particular issue she heard a lot of fear.

"What I wanted to get across to my colleagues and to the community is how very concerned people are and how much they hope there will be more consultation, more conversation and that this program will be put on pause until people feel they have been heard and they feel the program reflects what they actually need it to be."

All current recipients of Assured Income for the Severely Handicapped will be transferred to ADAP come July 1.

With the ADAP program they will receive a base rate of \$ 1,740 a month, \$200 less than the current AISH rate, and if they believe they should remain on AISH the recipient will need to be reassessed.

Councillor Rajko Dodic said Bill 12 is very complex and difficult to understand because it is 132 pages dealing with 14 pieces of legislation being amended.

“The only way you’re able to tell what the effect is, is if you have the old piece of legislation there and are able to have a look at it right beside the amendments. It is impossible to actually be able to review this with any degree of clarity.”

He added later on that upon cross examination from other organizations who spoke against the issue that he is not convinced the government did proper consultation when creating the program.

Councillor Al Beeber said that he believed it is council’s duty to advocate for those who are not receiving the supports they need to thrive.

“They are important persons in our community and we have a moral obligation to support them and I agree with the motion that we have a vested interest in ensuring people with disabilities receive the adequate finances so they can actually live.”

Deputy Mayor Jenn Schmidt-Rempel made similar comments saying when changes in provincial programs change and negatively impact residents its appropriate for council to elevate citizens voices.

“We have a duty as counsel to use our voice to elevate those in our city and relay feedback from our community to other orders of government.”

Councillor Mark Campbell emphasised due to the lack of definition within the legislation there needs to be more consultation.

“There’s a lack of definition, there is no right to appeal, there is no meaningful dialogue and the consultation needs to be there. We need to get that message to (the provincial government) and we need to get it before we don’t”

Council chambers erupted in applause following the unanimous vote.

Crowson encourages everyone to bring their concerns to council saying while council may not vote the way you want, they will always listen.

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